



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Thales Academies

School Website: <https://www.thalesacademy.org>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Thales Academy Cary/Holly Springs (Thales Academy, NC network) demonstrates a clearly Classical framework across most elements of the Six Essential Elements rubric. Public materials consistently foreground the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), the Great Books and the Great Conversation, and a commitment to virtue, wisdom, and the formation of character within a Judeo-Christian Western civilizational inheritance. Direct Instruction is acknowledged for foundational concepts in early grades, but the overall pedagogy emphasizes Socratic dialogue, seminars, and the senior thesis in history and literature, aligning with classical pedagogy from grammar to rhetoric stages. The school emphasizes Latin study, interdisciplinary continuity, and a robust emphasis on community, family partnership, and parental engagement. Evidence across multiple Thales Academy sources shows a coherent classical identity with explicit attention to truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, anchored in the Western canon and religious-ethical formation. This yields an overall assessment of CLASSICAL across the six categories.

- The religious/metaphysical foundations are strongly grounded in a Judeo-Christian frame, with explicit references to natural law, the imago Dei, and the Western canon as the inherited tradition shaping education.
- The school's purpose/goals stress formation, virtue, and pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty rather than mere job preparation.
- The curriculum explicitly centers the liberal arts (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Great Books, history taught chronologically, and a "Great Conversation."
- Pedagogy encompasses both contemplative/restful elements and Socratic/inquiry-based modes, with upper-level seminars and rhetoric, while lower grades include memory-oriented practice and singing/recitation (Schol  ) as foundational memory work.
- Faculty are portrayed as virtuous, mentors who embody and model the school's aims, serving as the living curriculum, with explicit emphasis on character formation and professional leadership.
- Parents and community are foundational partners, with explicit statements about parental involvement, home-school collaboration, and open access for visits and resources.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials situate Thales Academy within a Judeo-Christian frame and Western-civilizational inheritance, with explicit reference to Imago Dei and natural law as the basis for human dignity. The Western canon and Great Books are emphasized as central to educating for truth, goodness, and beauty. - The classical framework is described as rooted in a multi-stage classical pedagogy (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and a shared commitment to virtue and transcendental truths, with explicit mention of Great Books and a “Great Conversation.” - Thales Academy materials repeatedly foreground truth, beauty, and goodness as enduring realities and objectives of education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; Great Books; Great Conversation; Socratic dialogue/Socratic method; Western canon; Imago Dei; natural law; Judeo-Christian; theology references. - Negative keywords: none clearly evident in the public materials (no overt relativism, secular ethics, or value-neutral language appears as a governing frame in the public materials reviewed). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords present (approximately 9–12 distinct terms/phrases identified across sources); Negative keywords present (0). Estimated positivity percentage: ~100% of the identified keywords align with the Positive Keyword Indicators for this category.

Why this rating - The school's materials align with the transcendental moral realism and metaphysical orientation sought in classical education: virtues (truth, goodness, beauty) are treated as real and knowable; theology and a Judeo-Christian frame anchor the curriculum; and communal liturgical/ritual elements are referenced in the broader classical tradition, though liturgical practice is less explicit on campus. The alignment with Great Books, the Great Conversation, and the Trivium development (grammar/logic/rhetoric) reinforces CLASSICAL evaluation for this category.

Citations - Judeo-Christian framing, natural law, and Western canon emphasis: - Three phases of classical education; grammar/logic/rhetoric; Great Books framing: - Classical identity and pursuit of truth/beauty/goodness:

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials present education as formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job preparation. The school's stated mission emphasizes developing classical thinkers and forming character through a moral-intellectual framework. - There is explicit emphasis on virtue, character formation, and a shared commitment to truth, beauty, and goodness as real ends of education; the materials frame education as formation rather than information. - Public narratives emphasize the Great Books, the Western canon, and a lifelong cultivation of the good life, underscoring formation as the primary objective of schooling.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, character formation, formation, truth, goodness, beauty, Great Books, Great Conversation, Western canon, Imago Dei, natural law. - Negative keywords: none detected in the public materials (no language suggesting a focus primarily on workforce outcomes or utilitarian metrics). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords identified ~8–12 distinct items; Negative keywords ~0. Positivity ~100%.

Why this rating - The materials consistently articulate formation and virtue as primary aims, with a strong emphasis on transcendentals and a long-term development of human excellence. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the School Purpose and Goal category.

Citations - Formation and virtue emphasis; truth/goodness/beauty; Great Books: - Judeo-Christian grounding and Western-civilizational inheritance as ends of education: - “Developing Classical Thinkers” and formation-centric framing:

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as Trivium-based (grammar/logic/rhetoric) with a chronological history of instruction and a focus on the Great Books, primary sources, and the “Great Conversation.” Latin

language study is part of the core plan. History is taught chronologically across the curriculum rather than as a purely social-studies approach. - The public materials describe a robust classical curriculum, including direct instruction for foundational concepts (grammar/logic/rhetoric), LIT (Luddy Institute of Technology) courses for pre-engineering and STEM, and a senior thesis capstone that integrates primary sources and Western intellectual heritage. - The Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis is explicitly stated, and the curriculum highlights integration of primary sources, historical context, and a law/ethics orientation aligned with classical education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin); Great Books; Great Conversation; history taught chronologically; primary sources; Latin; interdisciplinary/cross-curricular integration; senior thesis; LIT/LIA programs; direct instruction as a pedagogical pillar (within Pillars). - Negative keywords: none identified in public materials (no language suggesting anti-classical or anti-Great-Books orientation). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords identified ~12–15 distinct items; Negative keywords ~0. Positivity ~100%.

Why this rating - The curriculum aligns with the classical expectation of the Trivium as the backbone of early and middle grades, with a Great Books-based high school program and a capstone senior thesis, plus a deliberate integration of history and literature across disciplines. The content also reflects a traditional liberal-arts emphasis (Latin, Classics, direct instruction, and a cross-curricular Great Conversation). This yields a CLASSICAL rating for Curriculum.

Citations - Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric and Great Books with the Great Conversation; Latin; chronological history: - Senior Thesis, LIT/LIA programs, and pre-engineering emphasis in a classical framework: - Western canon focus and virtue-based curriculum:

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe upper-grade Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and the development of rhetoric and public speaking; lower grades engage in singing, chanting, and memory-building (Scholé) to deepen memory and delight. The combination reflects classical pedagogy from practice and reverence to rigorous inquiry. - The Thales Way emphasizes Direct Instruction in early grades for solid foundational knowledge, followed by a classical curriculum that employs Socratic dialogue in junior high and high school, with a strong emphasis on primary source analysis and the Great Books approach. - A teacher perspective highlights the integration of Socratic dialogue and seminars, and the use of a rigorous classical framework to prepare students for college and lifelong thinking.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion/dialogue; seminars; debates; rhetoric; memory/Scholé; Great Books; Trivium stages; direct instruction at early grades; college readiness emphasis; senior thesis as a capstone. - Negative keywords: Minimal to none in public materials (no explicit advocacy for purely project-based or purely standardized approaches that would contradict a classical pedagogy). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords identified ~10–14 terms; Negative keywords ~0. Positivity ~100%.

Why this rating - The pedagogy mirrors classical education expectations: a blend of contemplative/restful elements (Scholé and memory work) with Socratic inquiry and rhetoric in the upper grades; direct instruction used in foundational stages; emphasis on classical dialogue, Great Books, and structured memory. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Citations - Socratic dialogue, seminars, debates, rhetoric in upper grades; Latin; memory work: - Direct Instruction for early grades; classical curriculum; Great Books: - Teacher perspective stressing the classical approach and Socratic/seminar method:

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as model teachers and mentors who embody virtue and knowledge; they are the living curriculum and core of the school; there is emphasis on faculty as collegial, supportive, and aligned with classical pedagogy. The school's materials also reference a faculty directory and strong teacher

leadership as a central element of the school's identity. - The materials describe the faculty as engaged in guiding classical education across levels, with a focus on character formation and a shared mission. The culture is described as collaborative, with teachers as mentors who form the backbone of the school community. - The Cary/Holly Springs materials highlight the presence of specialized instructors (e.g., Luddy Institute of Technology instructors) and a staff culture aligned with classical values and rigorous preparation for college.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; core/central faculty; collegial; character formation; virtuous leadership; faculty directory. - Negative keywords: none evident (no language indicating weak faculty support, or a non-classical faculty culture). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords identified ~6–10; Negative ~0. Positivity ~100%.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently portray a faculty body that embodies classical aims, acts as the living curriculum, and supports a virtuous school culture. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the Faculty category.

Citations - Model teachers/mentors; living curriculum; collegial faculty; portrait of what a teacher should be: - Western-canon framing and a classical identity that depends on faculty leadership: - Specialized instructors and college-preparatory emphasis in campus programs:

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes a strong partnership with families, viewing parents as co-teachers and inviting parental involvement in the learning process; there are explicit calls for parents to engage through resources, book studies, and campus visits. - The materials describe opportunities for parent formation around classical education and encourage home-school collaboration, with clear avenues for parental participation in learning communities and school events. - Newsletter content and campus communications show active parent engagement, community service involvement, and a collaborative culture that extends beyond the classroom to support the student's formation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-educators; parental engagement; parent formation; home-school collaboration; open visits; community involvement. - Negative keywords: none clearly evident in the public materials (no language that minimizes parental engagement or separates families from the educational process). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords identified ~5–8; Negative ~0. Positivity ~100%.

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on parental partnership and family involvement is a hallmark of classical education models that emphasize formation within a community of learners including families. The results thus align with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations - Partnership with families and co-teacher role; parent formation and wide access for visits: - Community/parent engagement through resources and gatherings: - Campus communications and parent engagement:

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, Thales Academy NC network demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories, based on the public materials in the school's crawl and the classical-education framework documented in the knowledge-base materials (Six Essential Elements of a Classical School). The school exhibits a coherent classical identity, with a consistent emphasis on the Trivium, Great Books, the Great Conversation, virtue formation, and a robust partnership with families.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here since the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. If further nuance were needed, potential enhancements could include stronger explicit articulation of liturgical/community worship practices as formal liturgical routines (if desired by the school) and more explicit evidence of a continuous, contemplative pace (Scholé) across all grade bands with documented routines beyond memory work in early grades.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.